HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

# What is Bitahon? Trust, Reliance & Faith

**Given Monday 25 May 2026** · HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem, Chapter 8 Part 1

**Sefer:** HaMaspik L'Ovdei Hashem (Kifayat al-Abidin) — Rabbi Avraham ben HaRambam **Chapter:** Perek 8 (ביטחון — Bitachon and Reliance) — Part 1 **Edition:** Feldheim **This week:** Defining Bitachon · The First Category (the prophets) · Too much and too little Bitachon

## Why This Chapter Matters

Chapter 8 is the longest chapter in the entire sefer. There are 13 chapters in HaMaspik, and after Chapter 8 the chapters become much shorter. The length itself signals how important this topic was to Rabbi Avraham. This chapter will take us through to at least the end of the summer term.

### Where We've Been in HaMaspik

| Chapter | Topic |
|---|---|
| 1 | The difference between a Chassid and a Tzaddik |
| 2-4 | Generosity, compassion, calmness |
| 5-7 | Continuing character traits |
| 7 | Humility (just completed) |
| **8** | **Bitachon** |

## Defining Our Terms: Emunah vs. Bitachon

### Emunah

**Root:** א-מ-נ (alef-mem-nun) → *amen* **Meaning:** firm, loyal, trustworthy

Examples throughout Tanakh:

> *You found Avraham's heart faithful before You"* (we say this every morning in Shacharit) — **ומצאת את לבבו נאמן לפניך**
>
> *I will fix him as a peg in a firm place"* (Yeshayahu) — **ותקעתיו יתד במקום נאמן**
>
> *He was the guardian of Hadassah"* (Esther) — when you adopt or raise a child, there's a kind of loyalty and firmness — **ויהי אומן את הדסה**

**Important:** Translating *emunah* as "faith" is misleading. "Faith" connotes blind acceptance. **Emunah means firmness in our beliefs** about Hashem and Torah — based on understanding, not blindness.

### Bitachon

**Root:** ב-ט-ח (bet-tet-chet) **Meaning:** secure, safe, confident — *stronger* than firmness

The classic verse from the end of the Torah:

> *Yisrael will dwell securely, alone, like Yaakov's spring"* (V'zot "וישכון ישראל בטח בדד עין יעקב HaBerachah)

In modern Hebrew, *betach* is everyday usage: *"Can I rely on you for this?" — "Betach!"* (Of course!) = 100%, no worries.

**Bitachon = confidence, security, very strong emunah**

### The Relationship

**Bitachon is the next level up from Emunah.**

- Without emunah, no bitachon is possible
- Emunah is the *intellectual* worked-out truth
- Bitachon is *living* that truth — applying it day-to-day

You can have emunah without bitachon. You cannot have bitachon without emunah.

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## PART 1 — The Foundational Definition

## Bitachon as a Foundation of Torah

הביטחון בהשם יתעלה ויתברך שמו הוא אחד המידות המעולות ואפילו יסוד מיסודות התורה

**Bitachon is one of the most exalted character traits and a foundation of the foundations of Torah.**

- Nobody ever disputed the centrality of bitachon
- It's discussed across the entire Torah and prophets
- The word/concept is on everyone's lips — both the common people and the elite

### A Crucial Caveat from the Rambam (Father)

Rabbi Avraham echoes his father's warning from the Moreh (end of Section 1):

Faith is not merely what is uttered with the lips, but what is apprehended by the soul. If you content yourself with giving utterance to words without apprehending them or believing in them, especially with the true God, you have a very easy task — many ignorant people profess articles of faith without connecting any idea with them.

It's easy to say *"B'ezrat Hashem"* many times a day. But what does it mean? **Bitachon must be planted in the heart (נטוע בלב) — not just spoken from the lips.**

This is hard. And working on this is the entire work of Chapter 8.

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## Bitachon Throughout Torah

### The Foundational Verse

כי על כל מוצא פי ה' יחיה האדם *"Man lives by everything that comes from the mouth of Hashem"* (Eikev)

### The Mitzvot That Embody Bitachon

The seventh year (Shemittah) and the fiftieth year (Yovel) are built on bitachon:

- No planting, no harvesting, no claiming produce
- This is *only possible* if you have bitachon

### The Only Question in the Torah

וכי תאמרו מה נאכל בשנה השביעית? הן לא נזרע ולא נאסוף את תבואתנו

**This is the only place in the Torah where the Torah itself paraphrases a question** — "What shall we eat in the seventh year, when we cannot plant and cannot gather our crops?"

Hashem's answer:

וצויתי את ברכתי לכם בשנה הששית ועשת את התבואה לשלש השנים *"I will command My blessing for you in the sixth year — it will produce enough for three years"*

The whole sabbatical system requires bitachon. It cannot work without it.

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## The Core Definition of Bitachon

ועיקר הביטחון הוא חיזוק האמונה כי השם יתעלה הוא הבורא והמפרנס, המחיה והממית, המחלה והמרפא, המעשיר והמרושש

**Bitachon is the strengthening of emunah that Hashem is:**

- The Creator and Sustainer
- Who gives life and death
- Who brings illness and health
- Who brings wealth and poverty

וכל מקרי העולם הכלליים והפרטיים חוזרים אליו... מלבד המשמעת והמרי

**All events in the universe — general and individual — trace back to Hashem. The only exception is human free will (obedience and rebellion).**

### What This Means

Bitachon is **not** mere emunah:

- **Emunah** = intellectual recognition of the truth
- **Bitachon** = living with that truth applied to every aspect of life

You can intellectually know everything traces back to Hashem and still not have bitachon. Bitachon is when this knowledge becomes the actual frame of how you experience life.

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## Sources Throughout Tanakh

The chapter cites a series of verses establishing the principle:

| Source | Verse |
|---|---|
| Hashem to Moshe at the burning bush | מי שם פה לאדם או מי ישום אלם או חרש או פקח או עור — *"Who gives a person speech, sight, hearing?"* |
| Devarim | וזכרת את ה' אלוקיך כי הוא הנותן לך כח לעשות חיל — *"Remember that Hashem gives you the power to make wealth"* |
| Ha'azinu | ראו עתה כי אני אני הוא... אני אמית ואחיה — *"See now that I am He... I give death and life"* |
| Yaakov | האלוקים הרועה אותי מעודי — *"God who has shepherded me my whole life"* |
| Chanah | ה' ממית ומחיה... ה' מוריש ומעשיר משפיל אף מרומם — *"Hashem causes death and life, impoverishes and enriches, lowers and elevates"* |
| Elifaz (to Iyov) | כי הוא יכאיב ויחבש, ימחץ וידיו תרפינה — *"He wounds and binds, He strikes and His hands heal"* |
| Asaf | כי אלוקים שופט, זה ישפיל וזה ירים — *"God is the judge; He lowers one and raises another"* |

### Saadia Gaon's Insight on "Death Before Life"

In **אני אמית ואחיה**, why does death precede life? Saadia Gaon (covered in our earlier learning) explained: to tell you there is life **after** death. The order itself communicates resurrection.

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## What True Bitachon Looks Like in Practice

ואמיתת הביטחון היא שיאמין הבוטח ויתן ביטחונו ואמונתו בכל העניינים בהשם יתעלה ולא בשום אמצעי מן האמצעים הרגילים

**True bitachon means placing one's trust in Hashem for all matters — not in any of the regular intermediaries.**

### Example 1 — Medicine

You have a headache. You take Paracetamol. You feel better.

עליו לדעת בלבו ומצפונו בוודאות שהתרופה לא הועילה לו אלא מאת הבורא יתעלה

**Bitachon means knowing with certainty that the medicine helped you only because Hashem willed it.**

### This is NOT Negating Medicine

This will be developed more later, but already Rabbi Avraham makes clear:

- The medicine itself, the science, the pharmacists — these are real
- They were discovered through human wisdom and effort

- They work 99.99% of the time
- **But they work because Hashem wills nature to continue running**
- At any moment, the same medicine could be made not to work

**Bitachon does NOT mean refusing medicine or rejecting human discovery.** It means recognizing that nature's reliability is itself dependent on Hashem.

### The Verse: מחצתי ואני ארפא

*"I have wounded, and I will heal"* — Hashem is in charge of both directions.

### Example 2 — Danger

והנהגה מזיקה לא תזיק אלא ברצון הבורא

**Something normally dangerous will only cause harm if Hashem wills it.**

Again — this doesn't mean to act recklessly. We don't put ourselves into dangerous situations. The point is the inverse: even regular, safe situations contain risk that Hashem allows or prevents.

### Example 3 — Business

You bought low and sold high. You made a profit.

יודע הוא במצפונו המוחלט כי לא יבואנו רווח מן הפעולות הללו אלא בחסד השם יתעלה

**You know absolutely that this profit came only by Hashem's kindness.**

You were sharp, clever, business-savvy — but ultimately the profits came from Hashem's will. As Onkelos translates *כי הוא הנותן לך כח לעשות חיל*: **"He has given you the wisdom and shrewdness to acquire wealth."**

The reverse is also true: if you lost money, **suddenly your shares dropped, you lost thousands** — that too traces back to Hashem.

זרע רב תוציא השדה ומעט תאסוף כי יחסלנו הארבה *"You will sow much seed and gather little — for the locust will consume it"*

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## PART 2 — The Three Categories of Bitachon

Rabbi Avraham now introduces a framework that will structure the entire chapter:

| Category | Whose Bitachon | What It Means |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | **The Prophets** | Reliance on miracles |
| 2 | **The Philosophers (Aristotle)** | Belief in God but no real bitachon — nature is fixed |
| 3 | **The Correct Category for Us** | Nature exists, intermediaries are real — but all subservient to Hashem and changeable at any moment |

### Critical Clarification Up Front

**Category 1 — reliance on miracles — is ONLY for those who have been *instructed* to rely.**

This is the easy thing to misunderstand. Rabbi Avraham is NOT telling ordinary people to rely on miracles. He is describing what the prophets did — and only when they had been told to.

For example: Hashem tells Avraham to go and offer Yitzchak. It would be easy to say *"perhaps I misunderstood, perhaps Hashem didn't mean it."* Avraham's bitachon was responding with full faith.

והאמין בה' ויחשבה לו צדקה — *Avraham believed in Hashem, and it was counted to him as righteousness"*

Even when **told** to do something extraordinary, **carrying through with faith** is itself an act of bitachon.

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## Category 1: The Bitachon of the Prophets

### The Definition

והוא התערטלות מכל האמצעים הרגילים והנטייה לסמוך על ניסים הסותרים את חוקי הטבע

**Divesting oneself of all regular intermediaries, and leaning on miracles that contradict the laws of nature.**

### Three Classic Examples

### Yonatan (Shaul's son) vs. the Plishtim

He went into the Philistine camp with only his arms-bearer:

אין להשם מעצור להושיע ברב או במעט — *"Nothing prevents Hashem from saving by many or by few"*

### David vs. Goliat

He approached Goliat *bekela u'bechalukei avanim* — with a sling and smooth stones. He took off the armor, helmet, and regular weapons of war.

**The verse says:** *"ki lo nissiti"* — the simple meaning is "I am not used to them" (he had no practice wearing armor).

**But Yonatan ben Uziel translates midrashically:** *"hari lo bahon mit'aved nissa"* — **"a miracle cannot happen through them."** David removed the regular weapons specifically because he was relying on a miracle.

### Eliyahu HaNavi — Sustenance from Heaven

- First, by the stream: Hashem promised water from the stream and food from ravens. Eliyahu went, relied, and was sustained.
- Then, when the stream dried up: Hashem sent him to the widow in Tzarfat. The flour and oil miraculously did not run out.

### How Did They Reach This Level?

The Rambam (in the Moreh, Section 2) describes 11 levels of prophecy:

- The lowest level is called **Ruach HaKodesh** — a strong feeling that Hashem is with you, that this is the right thing to do, but without a clear verbal communication

ביטחון ישר ושלם אשר כזה יכול להיגרם ברוח הקודש... או על ידי הבטחת השם יתברך לנביא בדרך התגלות

**This kind of bitachon happens in ONE of two ways:**

1. **Direct prophecy** — Hashem explicitly tells them (e.g., Eliyahu being instructed where to go)
2. **Ruach HaKodesh** — a prophetic intuition, a deep feeling of divine direction (Yonatan and David didn't receive direct words, but they had this inner certainty)

### Even with Prophecy, Bitachon Is Still a Merit

אמונת הנביא וביטחונו בחזון המתגלה לו אינם חוץ מהצדק ואינם נקראים ביטחון

**Even though they've been told this, it's still meritorious — they could have doubted, could have hesitated, could have said "maybe I misunderstood the prophecy."**

Avraham receiving Hashem's promise of children and the Land — Avraham believing it counted as *tzedakah* (righteousness). The believing is itself the act.

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## How Rare Is This Level?

מדרגה עליונה זו בעניין הביטחון יקרת המציאות היא. לא כל הנביאים יכולים לצפות להשגתה. וגם הנביא שהשיגה לזמן מה, אינו מצפה להשגתה בכל עניין

**This level is extremely rare. Not all prophets reach it. And even a prophet who reached it doesn't have access to it all the time.**

### The Critical Principle

**Even prophets are only on this level when they receive explicit divine instruction.** When they don't have prophecy or Ruach HaKodesh, they must use normal human plans — and they are not blamed for doing so.

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## Yaakov Avinu — The Pattern of Prophets

### His Bitachon Level

Yaakov clearly reached the highest level of bitachon:

- He left all his father's wealth (Avraham and Yitzchak were rich)
  *"He left Beer Sheva and went to Charan with only his staff"* — **ויצא מבאר שבע וילך חרנה במקלו**
- *Holech ragli* — he traveled by foot
- *Lo behema lirkov aleha* — no animal to ride
- *Lo chaver imo* — no friend with him
- *V'lo cherev lehagen al atzmo* — no sword to defend himself
- He slept on the ground with stones for a pillow

כי במקלי עברתי את הירדן הזה" (when later recounting it) *For with my staff I crossed this Jordan"*

### And Yet — He Was Afraid

### Fleeing from Lavan

22 years later, Yaakov is worried about Lavan and flees. When Lavan catches up:

כי יראתי כי אמרתי פן תגזול את בנותיך ואת בני *I was afraid, for I said: perhaps you would take away"*
*your daughters and my sons by force"*

### Approaching Esav

ויירא יעקב מאוד וייצר לו — *"And Yaakov was very afraid and distressed"*

He devised an elaborate plan — gifts, animals, divided camps.

### The Question (Raised by Mark in the Shiur)

*Did Yaakov lose his bitachon when Yosef was missing for 22 years and he lost his prophecy?*

**Rabbi Kada's nuance:** This is a different question. Yaakov lost *prophecy* not because of a lack of bitachon, but because of **sadness**. When you're deeply sad, prophecy doesn't come. The Rambam himself wrote that **he was sad to the point of near-depression for years after his brother Rabbi Avraham's uncle died at sea**. Sadness itself is an obstacle to prophecy.

The point Rabbi Avraham is making here is different: **even a high-level person like Yaakov did not rely on his bitachon all the time** — only when he had explicit divine reassurance.

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## More Examples — Shmuel and Eliyahu

### Shmuel and Shaul

After Hashem rejected Shaul as king (over Amalek), Hashem instructed Shmuel to go anoint David. Shmuel's response:

איך אלך ושמע שאול והרגני? — *".How can I go? Shaul will hear and kill me"*

This is a great prophet expressing genuine fear. **He's not punished for it.** Hashem gives him a workaround:

עגלת בקר תקח בידך ואמרת לזבוח לה' באתי — *"Take a heifer in your hand and say: I have come to offer a sacrifice"*

Shmuel uses subterfuge with Hashem's explicit approval.

### Eliyahu and Izavel

Eliyahu had reached extraordinary heights:

- Could rebuke King Achav: *"I have not troubled Israel — you and your father's house have"*
- Confronted all of Israel at Mount Carmel: *"How long will you straddle two opinions?"*
- The people couldn't even respond
- He slaughtered 450 prophets of Baal

And then:

> וירא ויקם וילך אל נפשו — from the threats of Izavel *".He was afraid, got up, and fled for his life"*

How could the same Eliyahu who confronted Achav and killed 450 prophets be afraid of one woman?

**Because at the moment of Carmel, Eliyahu was acting *bidvar Hashem* — "according to Your word, I have done all these things"** (and indeed the text says exactly this). When the explicit divine instruction was absent, he reverted to ordinary human responses, including fear.

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## Note on the Tension with the Shmoneh Perakim

The Rambam in his Shmoneh Perakim (Chapter 7) seems to imply that fear for Yaakov and Shmuel was a problem. **Rabbi Avraham here takes a different position** — there's no fault when the prophet has not been prophesied a specific reassurance.

There are ways to reconcile, but the simple reading of Rabbi Avraham is that the prophets' fear in unprompted situations was not a flaw.

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## Defining Ruach HaKodesh More Precisely

Rabbi Avraham now clarifies what Ruach HaKodesh actually is:

בהרגשה נבואית ועוז רוח אלוהי

**A prophetic feeling and a divine strength of spirit.**

Examples from Tanakh:

**ותהי על יפתח רוח ה'** — *"The spirit of Hashem was upon Yiftach"*

**ותצלח עליו רוח ה'** — *"The spirit of Hashem rushed upon him"* (Shimshon)

This is what Yonatan and David had when they relied on miracles in battle. It's not direct verbal communication — it's an inner certainty, an intuition, that this is Hashem's will and they will succeed.

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## David and Achish — Bitachon Through Intuition

The story: David, fleeing Shaul, comes to King Achish of Gat. Achish's servants identify David as the famous warrior. David is terrified — they will surely kill him.

What does David do?

וישנה את טעמו בעיניהם ויתהלל בידם ויתו על דלתות השער ויורד רירו אל זקנו

**He pretended to be insane** — scribbled on the doors, let saliva run down his beard. Achish dismissed him: *"This man is crazy — what use is he?"*

Where did this idea come from? **Hashem gave him this intuition** (eitzah).

### The Principle

או ישיא ה' לעבדו עצה שתגן בפחדיו

**Hashem will whisper to His servant a plan that will protect him in his fears.** When you don't have direct prophecy, sometimes you get divine intuition pointing to the right path forward.

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## The Critical Conclusion of Category 1

הוי אומר: כל התולה תקוותו בנסים בלבד לא הלא התאמה, ללא התגלות או ללא הרגשה אלוהית אמתית להם שהם, הרי הוא מתאווה למה שאינו ראוי לו וחוטא בחוצפה המביאה לידי חילול השם — אין ספק שיבוא על עונשו

**Anyone who hangs their hope on miracles alone — without preparation, without prophecy, without genuine divine inspiration — is wanting something inappropriate for them, sinning with the brazenness that leads to chillul Hashem. There is no doubt they will be punished.**

### Why This Is So Severe

The person who says *"I rely on Hashem!"* and behaves recklessly creates a double risk:

1. Their plans fail
2. **Everyone sees** that "the religious person trusted Hashem and failed" — creating chillul Hashem

This is why excessive bitachon (when not justified) is described as *chutzpah* — brazenness.

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## PART 3 — Too Much Bitachon vs. Too Little

This is one of the most striking sections of the chapter. Both deficiencies are punishable.

דומה הוא למי שביטחונו לוקה בחסר

**Excessive bitachon (when not warranted) is comparable to deficient bitachon.**

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## Example of Deficient Bitachon — Dor HaMidbar

The generation of the desert was given *everything*:

- The exodus from Egypt with miracles and wonders
- The pillar of cloud by day
- The pillar of fire by night
- Manna for food
- Water from the rock
- The Aron going before them, finding their resting places
- A cloud above protecting from heat
- The Shechinah dwelling among them
- Moshe Rabbeinu as a direct intermediary — *"Stand, and let me hear what Hashem will command"*

This is the highest level of miraculous reality in recorded history.

### Their Failure — The Spies

When Moshe brought them to Eretz Kena'an:

- Hashem had explicitly told them: *"See, Hashem has given you the land. Go up, possess it, do not fear or be discouraged"*
- They asked to send spies (*nishlecha anashim lefaneinu*)
- Moshe relented (*vayitav b'einai hadavar*)
- Hashem said: *shelach lecha* — *"You want this? Send them, on your responsibility"*

The spies returned with frightening reports. The people cried. Moshe insisted: *"Hashem who goes before you will fight for you"*. They didn't believe.

### The Verse That Captures It

> ובדבר הזה אינכם מאמינים בה' אלוקיכם ההולך לפניכם — *"In this matter you do not believe in Hashem your God who goes before you"*

**Result:** 40 years in the desert. The entire generation could not enter the land. Hashem's words:

עד אנה ינאצוני העם הזה ועד אנה לא יאמינו בי, בכל האותות אשר עשיתי בקרבו? *"How long will this nation provoke Me? How long will they not believe in Me, with all the signs I have done among them?"*

### Why Was This So Severe?

Because **with everything they had been given**, the expected level of bitachon was extraordinarily high. To fall below it was a catastrophic failure.

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## The Psalm That Captures This — Tehillim 78 (Asaf)

משכיל לאסף — האזינה עמי תורתי, הטו אזניכם לאמרי פי *"Listen, My people, to My Torah; incline your ears to the words of My mouth"*

The mizmor's purpose, says Rabbi Avraham:

וכוונת כל המזמור הזה הוא לחזק את האדם ולהמריצו על הביטחון

**The entire mizmor is to strengthen and arouse a person to bitachon.**

The mizmor describes their failure as:

דור סורר ומורה, דור לא הכין לבו ולא נאמנה את אל רוחו *"A rebellious and stubborn generation, a generation whose heart was not steadfast, whose spirit was not faithful to God"*

והבן את הדרך של המזמור הזה כי התורה סובבת על הביטחון, ועל ידי הביטחון נשמרת התורה

**Understand this mizmor: the Torah is centered on bitachon, and through bitachon the Torah is kept.**

A person without bitachon is described as *sorer u'moreh* — rebellious and stubborn — *meredbi'emunato* — rebelling against his very faith.

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## Example of Excessive Bitachon — The Ma'apilim

Now, the very same parashah (Shelach Lecha) contains the opposite mistake.

After Hashem decreed 40 years in the desert, some Jews said: *"Wait! We were wrong. Now we'll go up and fight as we should have done."*

They went up to fight the next morning.

### Why This Was Wrong

אבל זה נאמר לגבי מי שמזניח כל חלקי ביטחון, ולא לגבי מי שבוטח ביטחון בנביאים ודומה להם

**They had just lost the hashgachah. The conditions for the high-level bitachon were no longer present.** They had been *told* they would not enter the land — that this generation would die in the desert. To now rely on miracles was to claim a category they no longer had access to.

The Torah's harsh verdict:

ותזידו ותעלו ההרה *"You acted brazenly and went up the mountain"*

The word *zadon* (brazenness) is the same word Rabbi Avraham used to describe relying on miracles without authorization.

### The Beautiful Symmetry

In the **same parashah, the same story**, you see both deficiencies:

- **Before the decree:** They should have had high bitachon (they had all the signs). They didn't. They were punished with 40 years.
- **After the decree:** They tried to suddenly have high bitachon. They didn't have authorization. They were punished with defeat.

**Both are failures.** Both are deviations from where you are actually supposed to be.

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## The Request for a King — Another Example of Failure

In the time of Shmuel HaNavi, Bnei Yisrael requested a king to fight their enemies.

Hashem to Shmuel:

כי לא אותך מאסו, כי אותי מאסו ממלוך עליהם *"It is not you they have rejected — it is Me they have rejected from ruling over them"*

Shmuel's rebuke included a sign: **rain in the summer** (which is destructive in Israel) — to show Hashem's displeasure.

The people acknowledged:

כי יספנו על כל חטאתינו רעה לשאול לנו מלך *"We have added to our sins the evil of asking for a king"*

### Why Was This a Failure of Bitachon?

Because **Hashem was their King**. Asking for a human king was a tacit declaration that they didn't trust Hashem's direct kingship over them. It was deficient bitachon — relying on human structures of power instead of divine protection.

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## Final Principles for This Section

ובכן, אלה שהיתה עליהם תמיד השגחת ה' ותוכחת עבדיו הנביאים ועושה להם ניסים — חייבים שביטחונם בה' יתעלה יהיה שלם ומוגמר, וירידתם מזה נחשבת לחטא

**Those upon whom Hashem's hashgachah constantly rests, who experience prophecy and miracles — they MUST have complete bitachon. Falling from that is a sin.**

ומאידך גיסא, מי שמעז פניו וסומך על ביטחון כזה למרות חוסר הכשרתו ופחיתות סגולותיו — הרי הוא מבקש מה שאינו ראוי לו, במקום להשיג את קרבת ה' יתעלה ישיג ההפך הגמור

**On the other hand, one who brazenly relies on this kind of bitachon despite not being trained or qualified — seeks what isn't appropriate for them, and instead of achieving closeness to Hashem, achieves the opposite entirely.**

### The Talmudic Maxim

לא כל הרוצה ליטול את השם יטול *"Not everyone who wants to take 'the Name' may take it"*

You cannot self-declare into a higher spiritual category. Bitachon at the prophetic level is reserved for those who have actually earned that station.

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## Summary

### What Bitachon Means

- Complete reliance on Hashem
- Recognition that He is Creator of all
- Everything in the universe (except free will) is subservient to His will
- Living with security and serenity
- **NOT** rejecting natural means and intermediaries — Hashem created them
- Bitachon means knowing those intermediaries are themselves dependent on Hashem's ongoing will

### The Three Categories (Framework)

1. **The Prophets** — reliance on miracles (covered tonight)
2. **The Philosophers** — belief in God but no real bitachon (coming up)
3. **The Correct Category for Us** — nature exists, intermediaries are real, but all subservient to Hashem (coming up)

### Category 1: The Prophets' Bitachon

- Divesting from regular means
- Relying on miracles
- **ONLY by divine instruction** — either direct prophecy or Ruach HaKodesh
- Examples: Yonatan, David, Eliyahu, Avraham
- Even prophets cannot rely on this all the time
- Yaakov, Shmuel, Eliyahu all experienced fear when divine reassurance wasn't present — and they were not blamed for it

### Both Failure Modes Are Real

- **Too little bitachon** when the situation calls for it → severe sin (dor hamidbar)
- **Too much bitachon** when unauthorized → brazenness, chillul Hashem (ma'apilim)

The art is being in the right category for who you actually are, in the situation you're actually in.

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## Coming Up Next Week

We continue with **Categories 2 and 3**:

- **Category 2 — The Philosophers' Position:** They believe in God but believe nature is fixed and unchangeable. Their "bitachon" is therefore very limited.
- **Category 3 — The Correct Category for Us:** Recognizing nature as real and using intermediaries normally, while knowing they are all subservient to Hashem and can change at any moment. This is the bitachon expected of us.

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*B'Ezrat Hashem*

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